# DISTRICT MENTAL HEALTH PROGRAM, THE NILGIRIS

**Dr M Poornajith, MD., DPM**
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**Date**: 9th Jul 26

**To**
**The Selection Committee**
**Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar**

It gives me immense pleasure to recommend Saahas Ludhra for the prestigious Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar, in recognition of his exceptional contribution to adolescent mental well-being through innovative technology. At the age of sixteen, Saahas conceptualized and developed "SpeakUp Yuva AI," an empathetic, AI-based voice and text support platform designed to help young people navigate stress, anxiety, cyberbullying, and social isolation.

As a mental health professional evaluating this initiative, it is vital to clarify the distinct framework of this tool. *SpeakUp Yuva AI is explicitly recognized here not as a clinical treatment alternative, a diagnostic instrument, or a replacement for professional psychiatric intervention.* Rather, its true merit lies in its capacity as a low-barrier, non-judgmental digital well-being ecosystem. By providing a safe space for distressed youth to articulate their struggles, it acts as an empathetic gateway that combats social stigma and actively encourages users to seek formal, professional medical care when needed. It complements, rather than misguide or substitutes, existing public health frameworks.

What distinguishes Saahas is his acute sense of social responsibility and his commitment to ethical technology. His independently recognized achievement by the India Book of Records as the "Youngest to Develop an Empathetic AI-Based Mental Health Support System" underscores his technical aptitude. However, from a public health perspective, the real value of his work is its potential to serve as an early-intervention support mechanism that safely bridges the gap between distressed adolescents and formal healthcare systems.

Saahas embodies the qualities of innovation, leadership, and national service that the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar seeks to honor. This recommendation is extended in high appreciation of his visionary intent, creative capability, and dedication to youth welfare. I strongly recommend him for this national recognition.

Yours sincerely,

09/07/2026

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